

SECTION FOUR

Make Your Organization More Creative

CHAPTER 21

The Business Case for Curiosity

by Francesca Gino

Most of the breakthrough discoveries and remarkable inventions throughout history, from flints for starting a fire to self-driving cars, have something in common: They are the result of curiosity. The impulse to seek new information and experiences and explore novel possibilities is a basic human attribute. New research points to three important insights about curiosity as it relates to business.

First, curiosity is much more important to an enterprise's performance than was previously thought. That's because cultivating it at all levels helps leaders and their employees adapt to uncertain market conditions and external pressures: When our curiosity is triggered, we think more deeply and rationally about decisions and come up with more-creative solutions. In addition, curiosity allows leaders to gain more respect from their followers and inspires employees to make their relationships with colleagues even more trusting and more collaborative.

Second, by making small changes to the design of their organizations and the ways they manage their employees, leaders can encourage curiosity—and improve their companies. These advantages accrue in every industry and in creative and routine work alike.

Third, although leaders might say they treasure inquisitive minds, in fact most stifle curiosity, fearing it will increase risk and inefficiency. In a survey I conducted of more than 3,000 employees from a wide range of firms and industries, only about 24% reported regularly feeling curious in their jobs, and about 70% said they face barriers to asking more questions at work.

In this chapter, I'll elaborate on the benefits of, and common barriers to, curiosity in the workplace. I'll then offer five strategies that can help leaders get high returns on investments in employees' curiosity and in their own.

The Benefits of Curiosity

New research reveals a wide range of benefits for organizations, leaders, and employees.

Fewer decision-making errors

In my research, I found that when our curiosity is triggered, we are less likely to fall prey to confirmation bias (looking for information that supports our beliefs rather than for evidence suggesting we are wrong) and to stereotyping people (making broad judgments, such as that women or minorities don't make good leaders). Curiosity has these positive effects because it leads us to generate alternatives.

More innovation and positive changes in both creative and noncreative jobs

Consider this example: In a field study, INSEAD's Spencer Harrison and colleagues asked artisans selling their goods through an e-commerce website several questions aimed at assessing the curiosity they experience at work. After that, the participants' creativity was measured by the number of items they created and listed over a two-week period. A one-unit increase in curiosity (for instance, a score of 6 rather than 5 on a 7-point scale) was associated with 34% greater creativity.

In a separate study, Harrison and his colleagues focused on call centers, where jobs tend to be highly structured and turnover is generally high. They asked incoming hires at 10 organizations to complete a survey that, among other things, measured their curiosity before they began their new jobs. Four weeks in, the employees were surveyed about

various aspects of their work. The results showed that the most curious employees sought the most information from coworkers, and the information helped them in their jobs—for instance, it boosted their creativity in addressing customers' concerns.

My own research confirms that encouraging people to be curious generates workplace improvements. For one study, I recruited about 200 employees working in various companies and industries. Twice a week for four weeks, half of them received a text message at the start of their workday that read, “What is one topic or activity you are curious about today? What is one thing you usually take for granted that you want to ask about? Please make sure you ask a few ‘Why questions’ as you engage in your work throughout the day. Please set aside a few minutes to identify how you’ll approach your work today with these questions in mind.”

The other half (the control group) received a message designed to trigger reflection but not raise their curiosity: “What is one topic or activity you’ll engage in today? What is one thing you usually work on or do that you’ll also complete today? Please make sure you think about this as you engage in your work throughout the day. Please set aside a few minutes to identify how you’ll approach your work today with these questions in mind.”

After four weeks, the participants in the first group scored higher than the others did on questions assessing their innovative behaviors at work, such as whether they had made constructive suggestions for implementing solutions to pressing organizational problems.

When we are curious, we view tough situations more creatively. Studies have found that curiosity is associated with less defensive reactions to stress and less aggressive reactions to provocation. We also perform better when we’re curious. In a study of 120 employees, I found that natural curiosity was associated with better job performance, as evaluated by their direct bosses.

Reduced group conflict

My research shows that curiosity encourages members of a group to put themselves in one another’s shoes and take an interest in one another’s ideas rather than focus only on their own perspective. This outward focus causes people to work together more effectively and smoothly: Conflicts are less heated, and groups achieve better results.

More-open communication and better team performance

Working with executives in a leadership program at Harvard Kennedy School, my colleagues and I divided a group of participants into smaller groups of five or six. We had some groups participate in a task that heightened their curiosity, and then we asked all the groups to engage in a simulation that tracked performance. The groups whose curiosity had been heightened performed better than did the control groups, because the curious groups shared information more openly and listened more carefully.

Barriers to Curiosity

Despite the well-established benefits of curiosity, organizations often discourage it. This attitude is not because leaders don’t see the value of curiosity. On the contrary, both leaders and employees understand that curiosity creates positive outcomes for their companies. In the previously mentioned survey of more than 3,000 employees, 92% credited curious people with bringing new ideas into teams and organizations and viewed curiosity as a catalyst for job satisfaction, motivation, innovation, and high performance.

Yet executives' actions often tell a different story. True, some organizations, including 3M and Meta (formerly Facebook), give employees free time to pursue their interests, but these companies are rare. And even in such organizations, employees often have challenging short-term performance goals (such as meeting a quarterly sales target or launching a new product by a certain date). These goals tend to consume the free time people could have spent exploring alternative approaches to their work or coming up with innovative ideas.

Two tendencies restrain leaders from encouraging curiosity.

They have the wrong mindset about exploration

Leaders often think that letting employees follow their curiosity will lead to a costly mess. In a recent survey of 520 chief learning officers and chief talent development officers, I found that they often shy away from encouraging curiosity because they believe the company would be harder to manage if people were allowed to explore their own interests. They also believe that disagreements would arise and that making and executing decisions would slow down, raising the cost of doing business.

Research finds that although people list creativity as a goal, they frequently reject creative ideas when actually presented with them. That's understandable: Exploration often involves questioning the status quo and doesn't always produce useful information. But it also means not settling for the first possible solution—and so creative exploration often yields better remedies.

They seek efficiency to the detriment of exploration

In the early 1900s, Henry Ford focused all his efforts on one goal: reducing production costs to create a car for the masses. By 1908, he had realized that vision with the introduction of the Model T. Demand grew so high that by 1921, the company was producing 56% of all passenger cars in the United States—a remarkable success made possible primarily by the firm's efficiency-centered model of work. But in the late 1920s, as the U.S. economy rose to new heights, consumers started wanting greater variety in their cars. While Ford remained fixated on improving the Model T, competitors such as General Motors started producing an array of models and soon captured the main share of the market. Owing to its single-minded focus on efficiency, Ford stopped experimenting and innovating and fell behind.

These leadership tendencies help explain why our curiosity usually declines the longer we're in a job. In one survey, I asked about 250 people who had recently started working for various companies a series of questions designed to measure curiosity; six months later, I administered a follow-up survey. Although initial levels of curiosity varied, everyone's curiosity had dropped after six months, with the average decline exceeding 20%. Because people were under pressure to complete their work quickly, they had little time to ask questions about broad processes or overall goals.

Five Ways to Bolster Curiosity

It takes thought and discipline to stop stifling curiosity and start fostering it. Here are five strategies leaders can employ.

Hire for curiosity

In 2004, an anonymous billboard appeared on Highway 101, in the heart of Silicon Valley, posing this puzzle: "{first 10-digit prime found in consecutive digits of e}.com." The answer, 7427466391.com, led the curious online, where they found another equation to solve. The handful of people who did so were invited to submit a résumé to Google.

The company took this unusual approach to finding job candidates because it places a premium on curiosity. (People didn't even need to be engineers!) As Eric Schmidt, Google's CEO from 2001 to 2011, has said, "We run this company on questions, not answers."

Google also identifies naturally curious people through interview questions such as these: "Have you ever found yourself unable to stop learning something you've never encountered before? Why? What kept you persistent?" The answers usually highlight either a specific purpose driving the candidate's inquiry ("It was my job to find the answer") or genuine curiosity ("I just had to figure out the answer").

IDEO, a design and consulting company, seeks to hire "T-shaped" employees. These people have deep skills that allow them to contribute to the creative process (the vertical stroke of the *T*) and a predisposition for collaboration across disciplines, a quality requiring empathy and curiosity (the horizontal stroke of the *T*). The firm understands that empathy and curiosity are related: Empathy allows employees to listen thoughtfully and see problems or decisions from another person's perspective, while curiosity extends to interest in other people's disciplines, so much so that one may start to practice them. And IDEO recognizes that most people perform at their best not because they're specialists but because their deep skill is accompanied by an intellectual curiosity that leads them to ask questions, explore, and collaborate.

To identify potential employees who are T-shaped, IDEO pays attention to how candidates talk about past projects. People who focus only on their own contributions may lack the breadth to appreciate collaboration. T-shaped candidates are more likely to talk about how they succeeded with the help of others and to express interest in working collaboratively on future projects.

To assess curiosity, employers can also ask candidates about their interests outside work. Reading books unrelated to one's own field and exploring questions just for the sake of knowing the answers are indications of curiosity. And companies can administer curiosity assessments, which have been validated in a myriad of studies. These tests generally measure whether people explore things they don't know, analyze data to uncover new ideas, read widely beyond their field, have diverse interests outside work, and are excited by learning opportunities.

The questions candidates ask—not just the answers they provide—can also signal curiosity. For instance, people who want to know about organizational aspects that aren't directly related to the job at hand probably have more natural curiosity than do people who ask only about the role they would perform.

Model inquisitiveness

Leaders can encourage curiosity throughout their organizations by being inquisitive themselves. In 2000, when Greg Dyke had been named director general of the BBC but hadn't yet assumed the position, he spent five months visiting the BBC's major locations, assembling the staff at each stop. Employees expected a long presentation but instead got a simple question: "What is the one thing I should do to make things better for you?" Dyke would listen carefully and then ask, "What is the one thing I should do to make things better for our viewers and listeners?"

The BBC's employees respected their new boss for taking the time to ask questions and listen. Dyke used their responses to inform his thinking about the changes needed to solve problems facing the broadcaster and to identify what to work on first. After officially taking the reins, he addressed the staff in a speech that reflected what he had learned and showed that he had been truly interested in what they said.

By asking questions and genuinely listening to the responses, Dyke modeled the importance of those behaviors. He also highlighted the fact that when we are exploring new terrain, listening is as important as talking: It helps us fill gaps in our knowledge and identify other questions to investigate.

The importance of listening may seem intuitive, but my research shows that we often prefer talking over listening with curiosity. For instance, when I asked some 230 high-level leaders in executive education classes what they would do if confronted with an organizational crisis stemming from both financial and cultural issues, most said they would take action: move to stop the financial bleeding and introduce initiatives to refresh the culture. Only a few said they would ask questions rather than simply impose their ideas on others. Management books commonly encourage leaders assuming new positions to communicate their vision from the start instead of asking employees how they can be most helpful. It's bad advice.

Why do we refrain from asking questions? Because we fear we'll be judged incompetent, indecisive, or unintelligent. Plus, time is precious, and we don't want to bother people. Experience and expertise exacerbate the problem: As people climb the organizational ladder, they think they have less to learn. Leaders also tend to believe they're expected to talk and provide answers, not ask questions.

Such fears and beliefs are misplaced, my recent research shows. When we demonstrate curiosity about others by asking questions, people like us *more* and view us as *more* competent, and the heightened trust makes our relationships more interesting and intimate. By asking questions, we promote more-meaningful connections and more-creative outcomes.

Leaders can also model curiosity by acknowledging when they don't know the answer; admitting the limits of your knowledge makes it clear that it's OK to be guided by curiosity. Patricia Fili-Krushel told me that when she joined WebMD Health as CEO, she met with a group of male engineers in Silicon Valley. They were doubtful that she could add value to their work and, right off the bat, asked what she knew about engineering. Without hesitation, Fili-Krushel made a zero with her fingers. "This is how much I know about engineering," she told them. "However, I do know how to run businesses, and I'm hoping you can teach me what I need to know about your world." When leaders concede that they don't have the answer to a question, they show that they value the search for answers and motivate others to explore as well.

New hires at Pixar Animation Studios are often hesitant to question the status quo, given the company's track record of hit movies and the brilliant work of those who have been there for years. To combat that tendency, Ed Catmull, the cofounder and president, makes a point of talking about times when Pixar made bad choices. Like all other organizations, he says, Pixar is not perfect, and it needs fresh eyes to spot opportunities for improvement. In this way, Catmull gives new recruits license to question existing practices. Recognizing the limits of our own knowledge and skills sends a powerful signal to others.

Tenelle Porter, a postdoctoral scholar in psychology at the University of California, Davis, describes intellectual humility as the ability to acknowledge that what we know is sharply limited. As her research demonstrates, higher levels of intellectual humility are associated with a greater willingness to consider views other than our own. People with more intellectual humility also do better in school and at work. Why? When we accept that our own knowledge is finite, we are more apt to see that the world is always changing and that the future will diverge from the present. By embracing this insight, leaders and employees can begin to recognize the power of exploration.

Finally, leaders can model inquisitiveness by approaching the unknown with curiosity rather than judgment. Bob Langer, who heads one of MIT's most productive laboratories, told me recently that this principle guides how he manages his staff. As human beings, we all feel an urge to evaluate others—often not positively. We're quick to

judge their ideas, behaviors, and perspectives, even when they relate to things that haven't been tried before. Langer avoids this trap by raising questions about others' ideas. His curiosity leads people to think deeper about their perspective and to remain curious about the tough problems they are trying to tackle. Through his thoughtful questions, he is modeling behavior that he expects of others in the lab.

Emphasize learning goals

When I asked Captain Chesley "Sully" Sullenberger how he was able to land a commercial aircraft safely in the Hudson River, he described his passion for continuous learning. Although commercial flights are almost always routine, every time his plane pushed back from the gate, he would remind himself that he needed to be prepared for the unexpected. "What can I learn?" he would think. When the unexpected came to pass, on a cold January day in 2009, Sullenberger asked himself what he *could* do, given the available options, and came up with a creative solution. He successfully fought the tendency to grasp for the most obvious option (landing at the nearest airport). Especially when under pressure, we narrow in on what immediately seems the best course of action. But those who are passionate about continuous learning contemplate a wide range of options and perspectives. As the accident report shows, Sullenberger carefully considered several alternatives in the 208 seconds between his discovery that the aircraft's engines lacked thrust and his landing of the plane in the Hudson.

It's natural to concentrate on results, especially in the face of tough challenges. But focusing on learning is generally more beneficial to people and their organizations, as some landmark studies show. For example, when U.S. Air Force personnel were given a demanding goal for the number of planes to be landed in a set time, their performance *decreased*. Similarly, in a study led by Southern Methodist University's Don Vandewalle, sales professionals who were naturally focused on performance goals, such as meeting their targets and being seen by colleagues as good at their jobs, did worse during a promotion of a product (a piece of medical equipment priced at about \$5,400) than did reps who were naturally focused on learning goals, such as exploring how to be a better salesperson. The results orientation cost these salespeople, because the company awarded a bonus of \$300 for each unit sold.

A body of research demonstrates that framing work around learning goals (developing competence, acquiring skills, mastering new situations, and so on) rather than performance goals (hitting targets, proving our competence, impressing others) boosts motivation. And when motivated by learning goals, we acquire a more diverse set of skills, do better at work, get higher grades in college, do better in problem-solving, and receive higher ratings after training. Unfortunately, organizations often prioritize performance goals.

Leaders can help employees adopt a learning mindset by communicating the importance of learning and by rewarding people not only for their performance but also for the learning needed to get there. Deloitte took this path: In 2013, it replaced its performance management system with one that tracks both learning and performance. Employees meet regularly with a coach to discuss their development and learning along with the support they need to continually grow.

Leaders can also stress the value of learning by reacting positively to ideas that may be mediocre in themselves but could be springboards to better ones. Writers and directors at Pixar are trained in a technique called *plussing*, which involves building on ideas without using judgmental language. Instead of rejecting a sketch, for example, a

director might find a starting point by saying, “I like Woody’s eyes, and what if we . . . ?” Someone else might jump in with another plus. This technique allows people to remain curious, listen actively, respect the ideas of others, and contribute their own. By promoting a process that allows all sorts of ideas to be explored, leaders send a clear message that learning is a key goal even if it doesn’t always lead to success.

Let employees explore and broaden their interests

Organizations can foster curiosity by giving employees time and resources to explore their interests. One of my favorite examples comes from my native country. It involves Italy’s first typewriter factory, Olivetti, founded in 1908 in the foothills of the Italian Alps. In the 1930s, some employees caught a coworker leaving the factory with a bagful of iron pieces and machinery. They accused him of stealing and asked the company to fire him. The worker told the CEO, Adriano Olivetti, that he was taking the parts home to work on a new machine over the weekend because he didn’t have time while performing his regular job. Instead of firing him, Olivetti gave him time to create the machine and charged him with overseeing its production. The result was Divisumma, the first electronic calculator. Divisumma sold well worldwide in the 1950s and 1960s, and Olivetti promoted the worker to technical director. Unlike leaders who would have shown him the door, Olivetti gave him the space to explore his curiosity, with remarkable results.

Some organizations provide resources to support employees’ outside interests. Since 1996, the manufacturing conglomerate United Technologies (UTC) has given as much as \$12,000 in tuition annually to any employee seeking a degree part-time—no strings attached. Leaders often don’t want to invest in training employees, for fear that the worker will jump to a competitor and take their expensively acquired skills with them. Even though UTC hasn’t tried to quantify the benefits of its tuition reimbursement program, Gail Jackson, the vice president of human resources when we spoke, believes in the importance of curious employees. “It’s better to train and have them leave than not to train and have them stay,” she told me. But according to the Society for Human Resource Management’s 2017 employee benefits report, only 44% of organizations provide or support cross-training to develop skills not directly related to workers’ jobs.

Leaders might provide opportunities for employees to travel to unfamiliar locales. When we have chances to expand our interests, research has found, we not only remain curious but also become more confident about what we can accomplish and we grow more successful at work. Employees can “travel” to other roles and areas of the organization to gain a broader perspective. At Pixar, employees across the organization can provide “notes”—questions and advice—that help directors consider all sorts of possibilities for the movies they are working on.

Employees can also broaden their interests by expanding their networks. As I and my colleagues Tiziana Casciaro, Bill McEvily, and Evelyn Zhang have found, curious people often end up being star performers, thanks to their diverse networks. Because they’re more comfortable than others are with asking questions, curious people more easily create and nurture ties at work—and those ties are critical to their career development and success. The organization benefits when employees are connected to people who can help them with challenges and motivate them to go the extra mile. MIT’s Bob Langer works to raise curiosity in his students by introducing them to experts in his network. Similarly, by connecting people across organizational departments and units, leaders can encourage employees to be curious about their colleagues’ work and ways of doing business.

Deliberate thinking about workspaces can broaden networks and encourage the cross-pollination of ideas. In the 1990s, when Pixar was designing a new home for itself in Emeryville, California, across the bay from San Francisco, the initial plans called for a separate building for each department. But then-owner Steve Jobs had concerns about

isolating the various departments and decided to build a single structure with a large atrium in the center, containing employee mailboxes, a café, a gift shop, and screening rooms. Forcing employees to interact, he reasoned, would expose them to one another's work and ideas.

Leaders can also boost employees' curiosity by carefully designing their teams. Consider Massimo Bottura, the owner of Osteria Francescana, a three-Michelin-star restaurant in Modena, Italy, that was rated the Best Restaurant in the World in 2016 and 2018. His sous chefs are Davide di Fabio, from Italy, and Kondo Takahiko, from Japan. The two differ not only in their origins but also in their strengths: Di Fabio is more comfortable with improvisation, while Takahiko is obsessed with precision. Such collisions of these two approaches make the kitchen more innovative, Bottura believes, and inspire curiosity in other workers.

Have “Why?” “What if?” and “How might we?” days

The inspiration for the Polaroid instant camera was a three-year-old's question. Inventor Edwin Land's daughter was impatient to see a photo her father had just snapped. When he explained that the film had to be processed, she wondered aloud, “Why do we have to wait for the picture?”

As every parent knows, *why* is ubiquitous in the vocabulary of young children, who have an insatiable need to understand the world around them. They aren't afraid to ask questions, and they don't worry about whether others believe they should already know the answers. But as children grow older, self-consciousness creeps in, along with the desire to appear confident and demonstrate expertise. By the time we're adults, we often suppress our curiosity.

Leaders can help draw out our innate curiosity. One company I visited asked all employees to think about and articulate some “What if?” and “How might we?” questions about the firm's goals and plans. They came up with all sorts of things, which were discussed and evaluated. As a concrete sign that questioning was supported and rewarded, the best questions were displayed on banners hung on the walls. Some of the questions led employees to suggest ideas for how to work more effectively. (For more on the importance of asking good questions before seeking solutions, see [chapter 9](#).)

In one study, my colleagues and I asked adults working in a wide range of jobs and industries to read about three organizational elements: goals, roles, and how organizations as a whole work together. For half the workers, the information was presented as the *grow method*—our version of a control condition. We encouraged that group to view those elements as immutable, and we stressed the importance of following existing processes that managers had already defined. For the other half, the information was presented as the *go-back method*. We encouraged those employees to see the elements as fluid and to go back and rethink them. A week later, we found that the workers who had read about the go-back method showed more creativity in tasks than did the workers in the grow-method group. They were more open to others' ideas and worked more effectively with one another.

To encourage curiosity, leaders should also teach employees how to ask good questions. Langer has said he wants to “help people make the transition from giving good answers to asking good questions.” He also tells his students that they could change the world, thus boosting the curiosity they need to tackle challenging problems.

Organizing “Why?” days, when employees are encouraged to ask that question if facing a challenge, can go a long way toward fostering curiosity. Intellectual Ventures, a company that generates inventions and buys and licenses patents, organizes “invention sessions” in which people from different disciplines, backgrounds, and levels of expertise come together to discuss potential solutions to tough problems. The diversity of participants helps them

consider issues from various angles. Similarly, under Toyota's five-whys approach, employees are encouraged to investigate problems by asking why. After coming up with an answer, they are supposed to ask why this answer is the case, and so on, until they have asked the question five times. This mindset can help employees innovate by challenging their existing perspectives.

In most organizations, leaders and employees alike receive the implicit message that asking questions is an unwanted challenge to authority. They are trained to focus on their work without looking closely at the process or their overall goals. But maintaining a sense of wonder is crucial to creativity and innovation. The most effective leaders look for ways to nurture their employees' curiosity to fuel learning and discovery.

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CHAPTER 22

How Leaders Can Unlock Their Teams' Creativity

by Rebecca Shambaugh

As a leadership coach, I never miss an opportunity to ask senior-level executives what they see as critical for people and organizations to succeed in today's dynamic business environment. A while ago, I met with an executive vice president of a *Fortune* 500 company. This executive (let's call her Ashley) has built many national and global teams and serves as a highly inspirational leader for her organization and industry. Without reservation, Ashley told me that being creative and innovative are the top critical success factors—not only for companies but also for leaders and their teams. Research has validated these findings, identifying creativity as the top leadership competency for enterprises.

Ashley explained that leaders and managers can't continue to rely on the same ideas that have brought them past success. Nor can they be effective by surrounding themselves with people who parrot the leader's own ideas. "I don't want the people who work for me to just take orders or feed information to me," she said. "I encourage my teams to take risks in bringing fresh thinking and new ideas to the table, even if they are not one hundred percent correct." Ashley added that the complexities of today's marketplace require innovative solutions, which at times call for disruptive ways of problem-solving—ways that may challenge the status quo: "The business environment is too dynamic, and the level of change is too complex. We can't rely on the same ideas or same ways to solve problems or expand markets with the same thinking we've always fallen back on."

With this understanding, Ashley looks for talent that puts thought into novel ways to address an issue or make a decision, rather than someone who operates in a vacuum of expected solutions. She believes that leaders must ensure not only that they have the right talent on their teams but also that those teams can thrive. To this end, she wants leaders to create an environment that encourages innovative thinking and that inspires people to tap into, and share, their best ideas and limitless creative potential. But how can leaders achieve Ashley's vision to unleash the full range of top thinking in their teams? Here are some strategies to get any group's creative juices flowing.

Avoid getting hemmed in by process

Innovation is driven neither by processes nor systems; it's generated by human talent. No matter what procedures you have in place, only the creative confidence and drive of individuals—and the collective intelligence of teams—will take companies to new frontiers, revealing a better world and boosting an organization's bottom-line performance.

If a team is creatively blocked, a first step for leadership is to examine whether the processes that surround people are holding them hostage in their thinking. An overreliance on systematically following rules can shut down collaborative brainstorming, as some people may believe they have no flexibility to express outside options that run counter to the standard process—the way that things have always been done. If this is the case, try removing the limitations of particular procedural structures during your creative sessions so that everyone can feel freer to contribute without bureaucratic constraint.

Facilitate spaghetti throwing

In my work with client companies, I've observed firsthand that teams truly empowered to exercise their creativity are purposeful, engaged, and inspired to do great things. They find ways to make life better for customers. Since this is the goal of every competitive organization, today's leaders must provide the right environment for teams to tap into

their full range of creative thinking and ability. While research shows that 80% of people see unlocking creative potential as key to economic growth, only 25% think they are living up to their own creative potential. From the employer side, McKinsey & Company's research has revealed that an overwhelming majority of executives—94%—are unhappy with the innovative performance of their company. That's a huge waste of talent in an area where leaders can make a major impact simply by allowing the work environment to be more conducive to creative contributions.

To facilitate experimentation and encourage people to see what sticks and what doesn't, work on creating an environment of psychological safety—where Heidi Brooks from the Yale School of Management says, a leader “walks the talk and doesn't simply ask people to voice outside-the-box thinking, but also demonstrates the same behaviors himself or herself.” To inspire creativity, leaders should also encourage healthy conflict and debate. Instead of micromanaging, empower others and give them the reins to explore and take risks. Doing so can lead a group in unexpected directions. (For more on psychological safety on creative teams, see [chapter 17](#).)

Reveal “sticky floors”

Everyone has the foundation to become creative. They start with the belief that they themselves are idea generators with the ability to become a compelling voice for creative concepts. When someone on the team harbors the opposite belief—that they aren't inherently innovative—their self-assessment can quickly become what I refer to as a *sticky floor*: a self-limiting belief or assumption that can sabotage success.

As a leader, part of your role in managing teams is to use emotional intelligence to determine whether any team members are unknowingly holding themselves back from tapping into their talents and full potential. If even one person hides their creative light under a bushel, the whole team suffers. Take a proactive approach to address this issue: Help the team member see the sticky floor, and offer coaching and support to help them express innovative ideas in the team setting.

Encourage a growth mindset—one laced with mindfulness

As part of coaching team members off their sticky floors, you'll want to help them understand how to develop a growth mindset. The term *growth mindset*, coined by Stanford University professor Carol Dweck, refers to how a person thinks about their own abilities related to intelligence and learning. People with a growth mindset possess an underlying belief that they can improve through their own effort. They accept setbacks and don't see them as failures but rather see them as opportunities for growing and learning through a process of gradual improvement. This perspective is the counterpoint to a *fixed mindset*, in which people believe they have a set level of talent (or lack thereof) in a particular area and that they can't alter that level, no matter how hard they try. When team members encounter a sticky floor related to creativity, leaders should coach them, explaining how the internal belief that they can become more creative helps them continue to develop their skills over time, learning from their mistakes and making improvements. In short, developing a growth mindset is about helping people move from fear to courage, and from perfectionism to a level of excellence that's “good enough.” This leadership challenge calls for guiding people to step out of the norm, crack their old assumptions, and stay open to new possibilities for creative insights.

Studies suggest that a mindfulness practice can help teams amplify the results of a growth mindset by courting creativity. Many of today's leaders have lost their ability and the bandwidth to pause and prioritize what's important or to put time aside to plan and be creative while inspiring others to do the same. Yet this omission is a mistake, in light of research that reveals that meditation awakens creative impulses in several ways, such as by improving

working memory, cognitive flexibility, and brainstorming ability. Increasing mindfulness can be as simple as taking a walk in the middle of the day while focusing on your surroundings. Avoid the tendency to multitask. Get rid of tech distractions at set times for freeform thought, and do a simple breathing exercise, following the rise and fall of your breath to oxygenate your brain and ignite creativity. If the simple act of pausing to breathe and reflect can drive a whole team's creativity, then it's a step worth implementing.

The goal of getting your team to think beyond the box is a no-brainer, but figuring out how to actually achieve greater group innovation isn't. As a leader, you need to approach making this happen just as you would any other management challenge: creatively.

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CHAPTER 23

Build a Culture of Originality

by Adam Grant

If there's one place on earth where originality goes to die, I'd managed to find it. I was charged with unleashing innovation and change in the ultimate bastion of bureaucracy. It was a place where people accepted defaults without question, followed rules without explanation, and clung to traditions and technologies long after they'd become obsolete: the U.S. Navy.

But in a matter of months, the navy was exploding with originality—and not because of anything I'd done. It launched a major innovation task force and helped form a Department of Defense outpost in Silicon Valley to get up to speed on cutting-edge technology. Surprisingly, these changes didn't come from the top of the navy's command-and-control structure. They were initiated at the bottom, by a group of junior officers in their twenties and thirties.

When I started digging for more details, multiple insiders pointed to a young aviator named Ben Kohlmann. Officers called him a troublemaker, rabble-rouser, disrupter, heretic, and radical. And in direct violation of the military ethos, these were terms of endearment.

Kohlmann lit the match by creating the navy's first rapid-innovation cell—a network of original thinkers who would collaborate to question long-held assumptions and generate new ideas. To start assembling the group, he searched for people with a history of nonconformity. One recruit had been fired from a nuclear submarine for disobeying a commander's order. Another had flat-out refused to go to basic training. Others had yelled at senior flag officers and flouted chains of command by writing public blog posts to express their iconoclastic views. "They were lone wolves," Kohlmann says. "Most of them had a track record of insubordination."

Kohlmann realized, however, that to fuel and sustain innovation throughout the navy, he needed more than a few lone wolves. So while working as an instructor and a director of flight operations, he set about building a culture of nonconformity. He talked to senior leaders about expanding his network and got their buy-in. He recruited sailors who had never shown a desire to challenge the status quo and exposed them to new ways of thinking. They visited centers of innovation excellence outside the military, including Google and the Rocky Mountain Institute. They devoured a monthly syllabus of readings on innovation and debated ideas during regular happy hours and robust online discussions. Soon they pioneered the use of 3D printers on ships and a robotic fish for stealth underwater missions—and other rapid-innovation cells began springing up around the military. "Culture is king," Kohlmann says. "When people discovered their voice, they became unstoppable."

Empowering the rank and file to innovate is where most leaders fall short. Instead, they try to recruit brash entrepreneurial types to bring fresh ideas and energy into their organizations—and then leave it at that. It's a wrongheaded approach, because it assumes that the best innovators are rare creatures with special gifts. Research shows that entrepreneurs who succeed over the long haul are surprisingly more risk-averse than their peers. The hotshots burn bright for a while but tend to fizzle out. So relying on a few exceptional folks who fit a romanticized creative profile is a short-term move that underestimates everyone else. Most people are in fact quite capable of novel thinking and problem-solving, if only their organizations would stop pounding them into conformity.

When everyone thinks alike and sticks to dominant norms, businesses are doomed to stagnate. To fight that inertia and drive innovation and change effectively, leaders need sustained original thinking in their organizations. They get it by building a culture of nonconformity, as Kohlmann did in the navy. I've been studying this for the better part of a decade, and it turns out to be less difficult than I expected.

For starters, leaders must give employees opportunities and incentives to generate—and keep generating—new ideas so that people across functions and roles get better at pushing past the obvious. However, it's also critical to have the right people vetting those ideas. That part of the process should be much less democratic and more meritocratic, because some votes are simply more meaningful than others. And finally, to continue generating and selecting smart ideas over time, organizations need to strike a balance between cultural cohesion and creative dissent.

Letting a Thousand Flowers Bloom

People often believe that to do better work, they should do fewer things. Yet the evidence flies in the face of that assumption: Being prolific actually increases originality, because sheer volume improves your chances of finding novel solutions. In experiments by Northwestern University psychologists Brian Lucas and Loran Nordgren, the initial ideas people generated were the most conventional. Once they had thought of those, they were free to start dreaming up possibilities that were more unusual. Their first 20 ideas were significantly less original than their next 15 were. (See [chapter 20](#) of this guide for more on creative persistence.)

Across fields, volume begets quality. This observation holds for all kinds of creators and thinkers—from composers and painters to scientists and inventors. Even the most eminent innovators do their most original work when they're also cranking out scores of less brilliant ideas. Consider Thomas Edison. In a five-year period, he came up with the light bulb, the phonograph, and the carbon transmitter used in telephones—while also filing more than 100 patents for inventions that didn't catch the world on fire, including a talking doll that ended up scaring children (and adults).

Of course, in organizations, the challenge lies in knowing when you've drummed up enough possibilities. How many ideas should you generate before deciding which ones to pursue? When I pose this question to executives, most say you're really humming with around 20 ideas. But that answer is off the mark by an order of magnitude. There's evidence that quality often doesn't max out until more than 200 ideas are on the table.

Stanford professor Robert Sutton notes that the Pixar movie *Cars* was chosen from about 500 pitches, and at Skyline, the toy design studio that generates ideas for Fisher-Price and Mattel, employees submitted 4,000 new toy concepts in one year. That group was winnowed down to 230 to be drawn or prototyped, and just 12 were finally developed. The more darts you throw, the better your odds of hitting a bull's-eye.

Though the idea that volume ultimately creates quality makes perfect sense, many managers fail to embrace this principle, fearing that time spent conjuring lots of ideas will prevent employees from being focused and efficient. The good news is that there are ways to help employees generate quantity and variety without sacrificing day-to-day productivity or causing burnout.

Think like the enemy

Research suggests that organizations often get stuck in a rut because they're playing defense, trying to stave off the competition. To encourage people to think differently and generate more ideas, put them on offense.

That's what Lisa Bodell of FutureThink did when Merck CEO Kenneth Frazier hired her to help shake up the status quo. Bodell divided Merck's executives into groups and asked them to come up with ways to put the company out of business. Instead of being cautious and sticking close to established competencies, the executives started considering bold new directions in strategy and product development—directions that competitors could conceivably take. The energy in the room soared as they explored the possibilities. The offensive mindset, Carnegie Mellon University professor Anita Woolley observes in an *Organizational Science* article, focuses attention on “pursuing opportunities . . . whereas defenders are more focused on maintaining their market share.” That mental shift allowed the Merck executives to imagine competitive threats that didn't yet exist. The result was a fresh set of opportunities for innovation.

Solicit ideas from individuals, not groups

According to decades of research, you get more and better ideas if people are working alone in separate rooms than if they're brainstorming in a group. When people generate ideas together, many of the best ones never get shared. Some members dominate the conversation, others hold back to avoid looking foolish, and the whole group tends to conform to the majority's taste.

Evidence shows that these problems can be managed through *brainwriting*. All that's required is asking individuals to think up ideas on their own before the group evaluates them, to get all the possibilities on the table. For instance, at the eyewear retailer Warby Parker, named the world's most innovative company by *Fast Company* in 2015, employees spend a few minutes a week writing down innovation ideas for colleagues to read and comment on. The company also maintains a Google doc where employees can submit requests for new technology to be built. The document yields about 400 new ideas in a typical quarter. One major innovation was a revamped retail point of sale, which grew out of an app that allowed customers to bookmark their favorite frames in the store and receive an email about them later.

Since employees often withhold their most unusual suggestions in group settings, another strategy for seeking ideas is to schedule rapid one-on-one idea meetings. When Anita Krohn Traaseth became managing director of Hewlett-Packard Norway, she launched a “speed-date the boss” initiative. She invited every employee to meet with her for five minutes and answer these questions: Who are you, and what do you do at HP? Where do you think we should change, and what should we keep focusing on? And what do you want to contribute beyond fulfilling your job responsibilities? She made it clear that she expected people to bring big ideas, and they didn't want to waste their five minutes with a senior leader—it was their chance to show that they could innovate. More than 170 speed dates later, so many good ideas had been generated that other HP leaders implemented the process in Austria and Switzerland.

Bring back the suggestion box

It's a practice that dates back to the early 1700s, when a Japanese shogun put a box at the entrance to his castle. He rewarded good ideas—but punished criticisms with decapitation. Today suggestion boxes are often ridiculed. “I smell a creative idea being formed somewhere in the building,” the boss thinks in one *Dilbert* cartoon. “I must find it and crush it.” He sets up a suggestion box, and Dilbert is intrigued until a colleague warns him: “It's a trap!!”

But the evidence points to a different conclusion: Suggestion boxes can be quite useful, precisely because they provide a large number of ideas. In one study, psychologist Michael Frese and his colleagues visited a Dutch steel company (now part of Tata Steel) that had been using a suggestion program for 70 years. The company had 11,000 employees and collected between 7,000 and 12,000 suggestions a year. A typical employee would make six or seven

suggestions annually and see three or four adopted. One prolific innovator submitted 75 ideas and had 30 adopted. In many companies, those ideas would have been missed altogether. For the Dutch steelmaker, however, the suggestion box regularly led to improvements—saving more than \$750,000 in one year alone.

The major benefit of suggestion boxes is that they multiply and diversify the ideas on the horizon, opening up new avenues for innovation. The biggest hurdle is that they create a larger haystack of ideas, making it more difficult to find the needle. You need a system for culling contributions—and rewarding and pursuing the best ones—so that people don't feel their suggestions are falling on deaf ears.

Developing a Nose for Good Ideas

Generating lots of alternatives is important, but so is listening to the right opinions and solutions. How can leaders avoid pursuing bad ideas and rejecting good ones?

Lean on proven evaluators

Although many leaders use a democratic process to select ideas, not every vote is equally valuable. Bowing to the majority's will is not the best policy; a select minority might have a better sense of which ideas have the greatest potential. To figure out whose votes should be amplified, pay attention to employees' track records in evaluation.

At the hedge fund Bridgewater, employees' opinions are weighted by a believability score, which reflects the quality of their past decisions in that domain. In the U.S. intelligence community, analysts demonstrate their credibility by forecasting major political and economic events. In studies conducted by psychologist Philip Tetlock and described in his book *Superforecasting*, forecasters are rated on accuracy (did they make the right bets?) and calibration (did they get the probabilities right?). Once the best of these prognosticators are identified, their judgments can be given greater influence than those of their peers.

So, in a company, who is likely to have the strongest track record? Not managers—it's too easy for them to stick to existing prototypes. And not the innovators themselves. Intoxicated by their own eureka moments, they tend to be overconfident about their odds of success. They may try to compensate for that by researching customer preferences, but they'll still be susceptible to confirmation bias (looking for information that supports their view and rejecting the rest). Even creative geniuses have trouble predicting with any accuracy when they've come up with a winner.

Research suggests that fellow innovators are the best evaluators of original ideas. They're impartial, because they're not judging their own ideas, and they're more willing than managers to give radical possibilities a chance. For example, Stanford professor Justin Berg found that circus performers who evaluated videos of their peers' new acts were about twice as accurate as managers were in predicting popularity with audiences.

Make it a contest

Idea competitions can help leaders separate the wheat from the chaff, whether they're sifting through suggestion-box entries or hosting a live innovation event. At Dow Chemical Company, for example, employees participate in an annual innovation tournament focused on reducing waste and saving energy. The tournament calls for ideas that require an initial investment of no more than \$200,000, and those costs must be recoverable within a year. Peers review the submissions, with monetary rewards going to the winners. Innovation researchers Christian Terwiesch and Karl Ulrich report that over more than a decade, the resulting 575 projects have produced an average return of 204% and saved the company \$110 million a year.

When an innovation tournament is well designed, you get a large pool of initial ideas, but they're clustered around key themes instead of spanning a range of topics. Because people spend a lot of time preparing their entries, the quality can be good, but the work happens in a discrete window of time, so the contest is not a recurring distraction.

Thorough evaluation helps to filter out the bad ideas. The feedback process typically involves having a group of subject matter experts and fellow innovators review the submissions, rate their novelty and usefulness, and suggest improvements.

With the right judges in place, an innovation contest not only leverages the wisdom of the crowd but also makes the crowd wiser. Contributors and evaluators get to learn from other people's successes and failures. Over time, the culture can evolve into one where employees feel confident in their ability to contribute ideas—and develop a better sense of what constitutes quality. Because successful innovators earn recognition and rewards, everyone has an incentive to participate.

So start by calling for ideas to solve a problem or seize an opportunity, and then introduce a rigorous process for assessment and feedback. The most promising submissions will make it to the next round, and the eventual winners should get the staff and resources necessary to implement their ideas.

Cultivating Both Cohesion and Dissent

Building a culture of nonconformity begins with learning how to generate and vet ideas, but it doesn't end there. To maintain originality over time, leaders need to keep fighting the pressures against it.

We used to blame conformity on strong cultures, believing they were so cultish and chummy that members couldn't consider diverse views and make wise decisions. But that's not true. Studies of decision-making in top management teams show that cohesive groups are not more likely than others are to seek consensus, dismiss divergent opinions, and fall victim to groupthink. In fact, members of strong cultures often make better decisions because they communicate well with one another and are secure enough in their roles to feel comfortable challenging one another.

Here's the evidence on how successful high-tech founders in Silicon Valley built their startups: They hired primarily for commitment to the mission, looking for people who would help carry out their vision and live by their values. Founders who looked mainly for technical skill or star potential didn't fare nearly as well. In mature industries, too, studies have shown that when companies place a strong emphasis on culture, their performance remains more stable.

Yet there's a dark side to strong, cohesive cultures: They can become homogeneous if left unchecked. As leaders continue to attract, select, and retain similar people, they sacrifice diversity in thoughts and values. Employees face intense pressure to fit in or get out. This sameness can be advantageous in predictable environments, but it's a problem in volatile industries and dynamic markets. In those settings, strong cultures can be too insular to respond appropriately to shifting conditions. Leaders have a hard time recognizing the need for change, considering different views, and learning and adapting.

Consider BlackBerry: After disrupting the smartphone market, senior leaders clung to the belief that users were primarily interested in efficient, secure email. They dismissed the iPhone as a music player and a consumer toy, hired like-minded insiders who had engineering backgrounds but lacked marketing expertise, and ultimately failed to create a high-quality web browser and an app-friendly operating system. The result? A major downsizing, a billion-dollar write-off, and a colossal collapse of market share.

So to balance out a strong culture, you also need a steady supply of critical opinions. Even when they're wrong, they're useful—they disrupt knee-jerk consensus, stimulate original thought, and help organizations find novel solutions to problems. In the navy's rapid-innovation cell, the norm is "loyal opposition," says Joshua Marcuse, one of Kohlmann's collaborators in the Pentagon. "Agitating against the status quo is how we contribute to the mission."

In short, make dissent one of your organization's core values. Create an environment where people can openly share critical opinions and are respected for doing so. In the early days of Apple, employees were passionately committed to making the Mac a user-friendly household product. But each year, the Mac team also gave an award to somebody who had challenged Steve Jobs. Every one of those award winners was promoted.

Cohesion and dissent sound contradictory, but a combination of the two is what brings novel ideas to the table—and keeps a strong culture from becoming a cult. Here are some ways to hold these principles in productive tension.

Prioritize organizational values

Give people a framework for choosing between conflicting opinions and allowing the best ideas to win out. When companies fail to prioritize values, performance suffers. My colleague Andrew Carton led a study showing that across hospitals, heart attack readmission rates were lower and returns on assets were higher when leaders articulated a compelling vision—but only if they spelled out no more than four organizational values. The more values they emphasized beyond that, the greater the odds that people interpreted them differently or didn't focus on the same ones.

Values need to be rank-ordered so that when employees face choices between competing courses of action, they know what comes first. At the software company Salesforce.com, trust is explicitly defined as the number one value, above growth and innovation. This value communicates a clear message to employees: When working on new software, never compromise data privacy. Tony Hsieh, the founder and longtime CEO of online shoe and clothing retailer Zappos, prioritized employee happiness over customer happiness. WestJet Airlines identifies safety as its most important value. And at Give-Forward, a company that helps people raise money for causes, compassion tops the list. Although media coverage is critical to the company's success, cofounder Ethan Austin notes, "We will not push a story in the media unless we are certain that the customer whose story we are sharing will benefit more than we do."

Once you've prioritized the values, keep scrutinizing them. Encourage new hires to challenge the company's standard way of doing things when they disagree with it. They're the ones with the freshest perspective; they haven't yet gone native. If they familiarize themselves with the culture before speaking up, they'll have already started marching to the same drummer. At Bridgewater, when new employees are trained, they're asked this question about the company's principles: "Do you disagree?"

Solicit problems, not just solutions

When working with executives, organizational psychologist David Hofmann likes to ask them to fill in the blanks in this sentence: "Don't bring me ____; bring me ____." Without fail, they shout out, "Don't bring me *problems*; bring me *solutions*!"

Although leaders love it when employees come up with solutions, there's an unintended consequence: Inquiry gets dampened. If you're always expected to have an answer ready, you'll arrive at meetings with your diagnosis complete, missing out on the chance to learn from a range of perspectives. This solutions orientation may be especially common in the United States: In a study comparing American and German decision groups, psychology

professor Nale Lehmann-Willenbrock and her team found that the Germans made twice as many statements about problems and 30% fewer statements about solutions. “Americans are driven to find solutions quickly,” the researchers observe, “often without a complete and thorough analysis of the problem.”

When individual members of a group have different information, as is usually the case in organizations, it’s smarter to get all the problems out there before pursuing solutions. At the digital music company Spotify, instead of working on projects, people organize around longterm business problems. “If they were easy to solve,” chief technology officer Oskar Stål notes, “we would have solved them already. When we create a new team, people typically stay together on a business problem for at least a year. If it becomes successful, the team and mission will exist for a long time.” Angi (formerly Angie’s List) cofounder Angie Hicks holds weekly office hours to hear concerns from employees. And when Traaseth became the CEO of the Norwegian government’s innovation efforts, she again used the speed-date approach to give employees a voice. To make sure she had full visibility into problems, she asked people to name their three biggest bottlenecks and what they would like to safeguard or change. Only after gathering problems across a tour of 14 offices did she begin implementing solutions.

Don’t appoint devil’s advocates—go find them

UC Berkeley psychologist Charlan Nemeth has found that assigning someone to play devil’s advocate doesn’t overcome confirmation bias. Though people may pay lip service to considering the counterargument, they’ll stick to their own views in the end.

To make a difference, the devil’s advocate has to actually hold a dissenting view, not just voice it for argument’s sake, and the group has to believe that the dissent is authentic. Under those circumstances, groups look at more information *against* the majority view than for it, and they’re less confident in their original preferences. Role-played disagreements are rarely argued forcefully or taken seriously; actual disagreement is what stimulates thought.

Groups with authentic dissenters generate more—and better—solutions to problems. Abraham Lincoln famously asked his political rivals to join his cabinet, knowing they would genuinely hold contrarian views. At one Berkshire Hathaway annual meeting, CEO Warren Buffett invited a trader who was shorting the stock to share his criticisms. Of course, this strategy works only if the dissenter’s input is clearly valued and respected.

Model receptivity to critical feedback

Many managers end up promoting conformity because their egos are fragile. Research reveals that insecurity prevents managers from seeking ideas and leads them to respond defensively to suggestions. Employees quickly pick up on this attitude and withhold ideas to avoid trouble. One way to overcome this barrier is to encourage people to challenge you out in the open.

Years ago at the software company Index Group, CEO Tom Gerrity gathered his full staff of about 100 people and had a consultant give him negative feedback in front of everyone. When employees saw their CEO listen to critical opinions, they became less worried about speaking up. And managers themselves became more receptive to tough comments.

You can also encourage people to challenge you by broadcasting your weaknesses. Sheryl Sandberg, the longtime chief operating officer of Facebook, spoke to the 2012 graduating class at Harvard Business School about this challenge: “When you’re the leader, it is really hard to get good and honest feedback, no matter how many times

you ask for it. One trick I've discovered is that I try to speak really openly about the things I'm bad at, because that gives people permission to agree with me, which is a lot easier than pointing it out in the first place." For example, Sandberg tells her colleagues that she has a habit of talking too much in meetings. "If I never mentioned it, would anyone walk up to me and say, 'Hey, Sheryl, I think you talked too much today'? I doubt it."

For a culture of originality to flourish, employees must feel free to contribute their wildest ideas. But people are often afraid to speak up, even if they've never seen anything bad happen to those who do.

To fight that fear in the navy, Kohlmann rejected the military's traditional emphasis on hierarchy. Everyone communicated on a first-name basis, ignoring rank. "If you have an idea, pitch it to the crowd and run with it," he told members of his rapid-innovation cell. And he introduced them to people who had successfully championed creativity and change in the navy, to show them that innovation was possible.

Other ways to nip fear in the bud include applauding employees for speaking up, even when their suggestions don't get adopted, and sharing your own harebrained ideas. Without some degree of organizational tolerance for bad ideas, conformity will begin to rear its ugly head. Ultimately, listening to a wider range of insights than you normally hear is the key to promoting great original thinking.

If at first you don't succeed, you'll know you're aiming high enough.

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